DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Does the Soul Begin Where It Will End?

Daat Tevunot §88

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §88 (to the first three of the five levels) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Monday 13 February 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap

We are at §88, page 206 in the English. So far: the body reflects hester, concealment, and the soul reflects hearah, illumination. Their interaction mirrors the way God runs the world: what we see is concealment, but behind it a constant illumination is guiding us to the tikkun haklali. In the same way the body looks powerful, while the soul, hidden, is all encompassing. Last time we saw that the product of the interaction shows in the face. Now we turn to the consequences of the interaction at the different stages of human existence: this world, the next world, and the time in between.

§88: perfection comes first

The Ramhal opens with the final state, the perfect one, in which the soul is in full control and the body completely submissive. Surprisingly, he says this is also the state at the very beginning, when soul and body first join to form a new person.

The order is: full strength, then reduction, then return. When the soul leaves its source and joins the body, it must have its maximum potential, the level it can reach at the end. Then it is told to make itself small, until through its own actions it earns that level again. It cannot be created small and only raised at the end of time, because that would give the soul a whole new identity. "Therefore the perfection of man is fixed first. And then afterwards it's reduced. And then it comes back up again."

Mark emphasised that the key word is potential. If the soul were fully active, the body would be refined at once and there would be no task. So it comes with full potential and is told: keep quiet, the body will now lead; you can fight back, but you will not have full rein.

The Rabbi connected this to the Gemara that a fetus in its mother's womb has a lamp lit over its head and sees from one end of the world to the other. The soul arrives with full force and is then told to be quiet. He later clarified that he meant the very first moment the new person's identity is formed, not the whole pregnancy. Once a baby is born, all it cares about is food and drink.

Are all souls given the same?

Moshe asked whether each person starts with a different potential. The discussion went back and forth. One view was that the soul has the same power in everyone, and the difference is how far each person's body is willing to fight back: "did you allow yourself to be overcome with the animal or not?" Another participant suggested that some souls, like Moshe Rabbenu's, may be less diminished on entry. The Rabbi noted that even Moshe had a body that had to eat. He suggested that the soul is the same soul, and how much it is diminished may depend on what God wants.

The end state: a body with no power

At the end, in eternity, the body exists but has no authority at all. It cannot be otherwise, because the body is darkness to the soul; its whole nature is to conceal the illumination, so even a drop of authority for the body would keep the soul from shining fully.

The Rabbi stressed that this does not mean there is no body in olam haba. The body toiled in this world and must receive its reward. But it will have no will of its own beside the soul's, until it almost has no identity of its own, as if absorbed into the soul. "The body is there, but it's almost like a different name."

Three periods in general

The Ramhal first divides it generally into three:

1. **The soul in complete authority.** The world to come, and the first moment of a person's existence.
2. **The body slightly in control.** A strange in-between time, to be explained.
3. **The body fully in control.** This world. The soul can fight back, but the body can pursue whatever it wants, and even the greatest must constantly attend to it: "you're always going to have to eat".

Five levels

He then becomes more precise, giving five levels (from the top of page 210). First the Rabbi reviewed the basic timeline, warning, "if we don't understand this we can't continue". This world lasts six thousand years. The next thousand years, the seventh millennium, the world is desolate. Olam haba begins around the year seven thousand. But the soul refining the body is a process, after being oppressed for so long, and its full extent is reached only at ten thousand. "This is very, very Kabbalistic things, but he's going to give it in such a simple way to us."

- **Level one.** The body exists, with arms, eyes and ears, but has no authority at all and no trace of physicality: no hunger, no thirst, no bodily needs, and no memory of our physical struggles. This is the very beginning of a person and the very end.
- **Level two.** The body has a korshit, a tiny drop of power, like a vague general memory of what it once was. The Rabbi compared it to someone who has come through a terrible, stressful time: everything is resolved, but he still feels a weariness he cannot pin down. Or a wedding day, the happiest day of your life, with something niggling you cannot put your finger on. The soul cannot spread out completely.

- **Level three.** The soul is in control and the body submissive, but the body retains some specific memories of the past and some slight physicality.

The Rabbi gave rough figures: if level one is 100, level two is 99 or so, and level three about 95. All three come after the year seven thousand. As he set it out, after seven thousand the soul takes control with the weariness of the third level; later comes the second level, where you cannot put your finger on it; and at ten thousand the first level, complete dominion. Level four is the period from six to seven thousand, and level five is our present world, from the beginning until six thousand. Those two, and how it all fits together, are for the next class.

Summary

- §88: the perfect state, with the soul fully in command and the body submissive, exists at the very beginning of a person and returns at the very end.
- The soul arrives with full potential, as the Gemara's image of the lamp over the fetus suggests, and is then reduced so that free choice is possible.
- In olam haba there is a body, but with no power or will of its own.
- In general there are three periods; more precisely, five levels of the body's power.
- Levels one to three come after the year seven thousand; level four is the seventh millennium and level five is this world.

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